

Let Law Students Become Law Students First

A resolution on accelerated law-firm recruiting, sponsored by the Bar Association of the District of Columbia

WHAT WE ASK YOU TO ADOPT

A resolution urging law schools, legal employers, bar associations, and other stakeholders to:

1. **Study** how accelerating recruitment timelines affect legal education, student well-being, and the entry-level hiring market; and
2. **Consider**, in their own recruiting practices, the educational, professional, and equitable interests of law students.

It mandates nothing. It blames no one. It asks the profession to study a problem it has already begun to name.

85%

of 2L summer offers now made before July of the 1L year, up from 34% a year earlier

80%

of offers now come through employer-sponsored recruiting, not on-campus interviews

18

law-school student governments asked the ABA to act

WHY IT MATTERS

Since 2024, hiring for the largest sectors of private practice has moved into the first semester of the first year, sometimes the first weeks. Students now make career-defining choices before they have learned to read a case, take a cold call, or sit for a single exam. A majority of the Class of 2028 report that this timing harmed them, and three in four surveyed students tie rising anxiety directly to recruiting pressure. The change also narrows access: students with family or industry connections navigate the compressed calendar far more easily than first-generation students, who report the lowest awareness of these timelines before they enroll. This is not students against firms. Giving the first year room to breathe means better-prepared students, better-matched hires, and classrooms that can teach again.

"It should give us pause that one of the forces exerting the most pressure on the structure of the first-year curriculum is not pedagogical reform or accreditation standards, but employer recruiting activity."

Nikia Gray, Executive Director, National Association for Law Placement (NALP)



Please vote to ADOPT.

Scan for the one-page summary, the full resolution, the data, and the coalition, at codesisyphus.github.io/law-student-hiring-resolution

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Study the problem.

Protect the first year.

Adopt the resolution.

Four concerns, one modest response

1. Integrity of the first-year curriculum.

The 1L year builds the analytical, ethical, and professional foundation of a lawyer's career. When recruiting begins in week one, employer activity, not pedagogy, drives the calendar. As one associate dean put it, "we need law students to become law students first."

2. Student well-being.

Students face professionally consequential decisions before their first exam. Seventy-five percent of surveyed students attribute increased anxiety specifically to recruiting pressure; a majority of the Class of 2028 report a negative impact.

3. Equity and access.

Only 25% of students knew these timelines before enrolling, and that awareness concentrated among continuing-generation graduates and the most selective schools. A compressed calendar rewards pre-existing networks and disadvantages first-generation students.

4. Health of the hiring market.

Employers now hire on less information about academic performance and demonstrated interest. Commentators call it a "lose-lose-lose" for students, schools, and firms: a collective-action problem no one party can solve alone.

THE STUDENTS ASKED FIRST

On January 1, 2026, student governments at **18 law schools** (Columbia, Cornell, Duke, Georgetown, Harvard, Michigan, Northwestern, NYU, Penn, Stanford, Texas, UC Berkeley, UCLA, Chicago, Virginia, Vanderbilt, WashU, and Yale) jointly asked the ABA to review accelerating recruitment. Several backed the request with supermajority student polls.



WHY THE ABA

No single firm can step back without losing talent to the firm beside it, and no single school can either. Only a national body can prompt the collective action no one player can start alone. That is the ABA's role. By urging study, it also produces what the profession still lacks: reliable, shared data on what this calendar is doing to legal education, and the footing to adopt a measure adequate to the problem. It prescribes no timeline and assigns no blame. It orders the diagnosis, not the cure.

Status: Approved by the BADC Board of Directors, July 15, 2026; recommended by the BADC Young Lawyers Section. The drafters are aware of **no opposition**. Builds on existing ABA policy 23A523 (holistic evaluation) and 24A515 (OCI pay transparency).

Sources: NALP, *Perspectives on 2025 Law Student Recruiting* (Jan. 2026); LSAC & NALP, *2025 1L Class: Student Awareness and Impact of Accelerated Big Law Recruitment* (June 2026); Law.com (June 11, 2026); BCG Attorney Search (Feb. 2026); ABA Journal (May 14, 2026); Bloomberg Law (Dec. 11, 2025); Coalition Letter to the ABA Section of Legal Education (Jan. 1, 2026). Full citations at the site above.